

Upgradation, however, isn't so easy to figure out. When performing an upgrade, keep Windows settings, your personal files and installed applications in mind. Depending on which version of the OS you're upgrading from, you may or may not be able to keep one or more of them. Beginning with the second most famous OS currently, we'll show you the options you've got.

Windows XP to Windows 8: Windows 8 allows you to upgrade from Windows XP only if service pack 3 is installed. You won't be able to carry over your applications or settings, only the files.

Windows Vista to Windows 8: If you've not installed SP1 on your Windows Vista installation, then you can only keep the files; no applications or settings will be carried over. With SP1 installed, you can migrate the data as well as system settings but applications still won't migrate.

Windows 7 to Windows 8: The scene is a little complicated in this case. Since Windows 7 is the immediate predecessor of Windows 8, it's possible to keep either only your files or everything (system settings, applications and files). However, for some strange reason it doesn't appear to support the migration of only files and settings while ignoring the applications.

Windows 8 to Windows 8 Pro: This would be applicable if you were to upgrade from Windows 8 to Windows 8 Pro. Here too, like Windows 7, you can bring across just the personal files or the trio of Files + Applications + Settings but you can't have just the settings and the files.

We just spoke about the Windows versions that are upgradable to Windows 8. But, you can't just upgrade Windows 7 Ultimate to Windows 8. You'd only be able to upgrade it to Windows 8 Pro. While the Basic, Home and Home Premium editions of Windows 7 can be upgraded to Windows 8, the Professional and Ultimate versions can be upgraded to Windows 8 Pro only. Again, Windows 7 Professional and Windows 7 Enterprise can be upgraded to Windows 8 Enterprise.

To be able to upgrade from one version of Windows to another, you'll need to download the Windows 8 Upgrade Assistant and run it on your PC. It will tell you what you can take over to the new OS and what must be left behind (actually, deleted). 